

Technical and Business Writing

TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION IN THE WORKPLACE

CHAPTER: 1

Features	Purpose	Writer's Knowledge of Topic	Audience	Criteria of Evaluation	Graphic Elements
Academic Writing	Communicating what the student knows about the topic to earn a high grade	Less than the teacher who evaluates the writing	The teacher who assigned the project or classmates	Depth, logic, clarity, unity, supporting evidence, and grammar	Sometimes used to explain and persuade
Workplace Writing	Getting something done within an organization	Usually more than the reader's knowledge	Often several people with differing professional backgrounds	Clear content organization, appropriate to the needs of busy readers	Frequently used to help readers find information and understand ideas

TECHNICAL DOCUMENTS

Correspondence

Memos to your boss and to your
Routine letters to customers, vendors etc
Letters to customers
Sales letters to potential customers
Electronic mail to co-workers or customers

Short Reports

Analysis of problem
Recommendation
Equipment Evaluation
Progress or periodic report
Description of results of a laboratory work or a company trip

Long Reports

Project report in field or laboratory work
Proposal and Feasibility study

Other Examples

Abstract or summary of technical articles
Technical article or presentation
Operation manual
Website

Features of Technical Writing

1. Purposeful
objective/focused

1. Contextualized
context based/ situation
oriented

Realistic
factual and
demonstrable

1. Directional
specific audience

**Outcome-
based**
Achieves targets

Interdisciplinary
Multiple fields



Use a Programmable Thermostat Properly

A programmable thermostat is ideal for people who are away from home during set periods of time throughout the week. Through proper use of pre-programmed settings, a programmable thermostat can save you about \$180 every year in energy costs.

Overview information summarizes the document's main point

How Do You Choose the Right One for You?

Heading is phrased as the main question readers will ask

To decide which model is best for you, think about your schedule and how often you are away from home for regular periods of time—work, school, other activities—and then decide which of the three different models best fits your schedule:

7-day models are best if your daily schedule tends to change; for example, if children are at home earlier on some days. These models give you the most flexibility and let you set different programs for different days—usually with four possible temperature periods per day.

Paragraphs and sentences are short

5+2-day models use the same schedule every weekday, and another for weekends.

Color is used to highlight key items

5-1-1 models are best if you tend to keep one schedule Monday through Friday and another schedule on Saturdays and Sundays.

Programmable Thermostat Settings

You can use the table below as a starting point for setting energy-saving temperatures, and then adjust the settings to fit your family's schedule and stay comfortable.

Setting	Time	Setpoint Temperature (Heat)	Setpoint Temperature (Cool)
Wake	6:00 a.m.	< 70° F	> 78° F
Day	8:00 a.m.	Setback at least 8° F	Setup at least 7° F
Evening	6:00 p.m.	< 70° F	> 78° F
Sleep	10:00 p.m.	Setback at least 8° F	Setup at least 4° F

Table provides easy-to-read comparative data

Purpose of Technical Writing

Q1. Am I writing primarily to create a record or provide information, to request or to persuade?

People in the working world communicate technical information for a number of purposes, many of which fall into one of two categories:

- To help others learn about a subject, carry out a task, or make a decision.
- To reinforce or change attitudes and motivate readers to take an action.

Technical Writing is done by an informed writer conveying needed information to an uninformed reader.

Audience of Technical Writing

Q2. Who will read what I have written?

- ✓ Supervisors and their Superiors
- ✓ Colleagues in your own department
- ✓ Subordinates in your department
- ✓ Employees and other departments or branches
- ✓ Clients
- ✓ Subcontractors and vendors
- ✓ Professors/ Members of selection committees
- ✓ HR Manager



Tone in Technical Writing

Tone refers to the writer's attitude/ emotional character towards the reader and the subject of the message.

Factual	Usually serious to a lighter tone
Neutral	Appropriate to the target audience
Sincere	Avoids a strong emotion
Non-discriminative	Flat/ Even



Tone in Technical Writing

- Polite tone (especially those who outrank you)
- Don't sound too tough or demanding about potentially sensitive issues.
- Phrase your sentences in a nonthreatening way
- Emphasize the reader's viewpoint – the **“you” approach**

Writer-centered Perspective	Reader-centered Perspective
If I can answer any questions, I'll be happy to do so. We shipped the order this morning I'm happy to report that . . .	If you have any questions, please ask. Your order was shipped this morning. You'll be glad to know that . . .

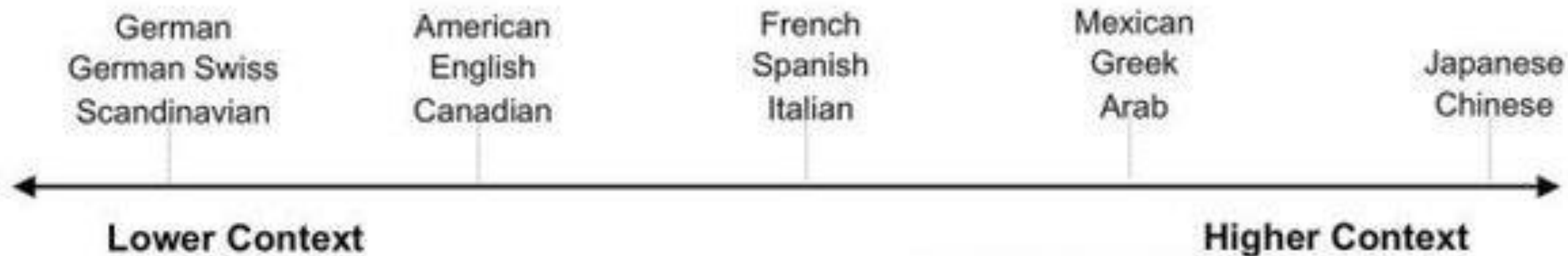
Negative Wording	Positive Wording
• We cannot process your claim because the necessary forms have not been completed. • We do not take phone calls after 3:00 PM on Fridays. • We closed your case because we never received the information requested in our letter of April 2.	• Your claim can be processed as soon as you complete the necessary forms. • You may reach us by telephone on Fridays until 3 PM. • Your case will be reactivated as soon as you provide the information requested in our April 2 letter.

Email Writing Guidelines

- Maintain a high level of **professionalism** in your use of e-mail.
 - Do not forward jokes or spam, discuss office gossip, or use biased language.
 - Do not send flames (e-mails that contain abusive, obscene, or derogatory language) to attack someone.
 - Do not use clever or hobby-related e-mail usernames (sushilover@ domain.com); instead use, e.g. msmith@domain.com.
 - Do not use emoticons
- Provide a **subject line** that describes the topic and focus of your message.
- Adapt **forwarded messages**: revise the subject line to reflect the current content and cut irrelevant previous text, based on your purpose and context.
- Use the “**cc:**” (courtesy copy) address line thoughtfully to keep others informed and follow your organization’s practice or protocol for copying messages to others.
- Include a cover message for all e-mail messages with **attachments** (“Attached is a copy of my budget proposal for your review. . . .”).
- Do not write in ALL UPPERCASE LETTERS or in all lowercase letters.
- Avoid **abbreviations** (BTW for by the way) used in personal e-mail, chat rooms, and text messaging.

Understanding Cultures

- All cultures have both common features and distinctive differences that must be studied. People in different cultures have different ways of thinking, different ways of acting and different expectations in communication.
- One of the ways that differences between cultures can be understood is through the concepts of high-context cultures and low-context cultures.



Low Context

Communication:

- Specific
- Detailed
- Precise

Poorer at decoding:

- Unspoken message
- Body language

High Context

Communication:

- Less direct

Emphasis on:

- Human relations

More sensitivity to:

- Non-verbals
- Feelings of others

Following are some basic guidelines to reduce the risk of misunderstanding:

- Simplify grammar and style rules.
- Use simple verb tenses and verb constructions.
- Limit vocabulary to words with clear meanings.
- Use language and terminology consistently.
- Define technical terms.
- Avoid slang terms and idioms.
- Include visuals.

Case Study: Intercultural Communication in a Global Business Environment

GlobalTech Solutions (GTS) is a multinational technology company headquartered in the United States, with offices in Europe, Asia, and South America. The company specializes in software development, IT consulting, and digital transformation services. GTS recently acquired a smaller tech firm, TechInnovate, based in Pakistan, to expand its market presence in Asia. As part of the acquisition, GTS plans to integrate TechInnovate's employees into its global operations. This integration involves a series of virtual meetings, cross-cultural training sessions, and collaborative projects between teams in the U.S. and Pakistan.

In the first virtual meeting between the U.S. and Pakistani teams, several communication issues arise. The American team notices that their Pakistani counterparts are unusually quiet during discussions. They rarely voice their opinions or disagree with any points made. Meanwhile, the Pakistani team feels that the American team is overly direct and somewhat aggressive in their approach, which makes them uncomfortable.

Key Players:

- John Davis: Project Manager from the U.S. team, known for his direct communication style.
- Saba Ali: Senior Developer from the Pakistani team, values harmony and prefers a consensus-driven approach.
- Sarah Lee: HR Manager at GTS, responsible for overseeing the integration process.
- Aslam Khan : HR Manager at TechInnovate, tasked with supporting the transition.

Questions:

Question 1: What are the key cultural differences in communication styles between the U.S. and Japanese teams?

Question 2: How can GTS facilitate better communication between the teams?

Question 3: What strategies can John and Saba use to improve their collaboration?

Question 4: How can the HR managers, Sarah and Aslam, support a smoother integration process?

Ethics in the Workplace

“our product is just what you need”

“our artificial sweetener is composed of proteins that occur naturally in the human body [amino acids].”

“our Krunchy Cookies contain no cholesterol”

Such claims are technically accurate but misleading.

Amino acids in certain sweeteners can alter body chemistry and cause headaches, seizures and possible brain tumors

Processed food snacks often contain saturated fat and trans fats, from which liver produces cholesterol

In addition to being informative and persuasive, communicators must be ethical.

0	<i>Meaning</i>	<i>Examples</i>
Suppression of Information	Burying to data to hide inconvenient truths	A company fails to reveal product-testing results that indicate potential danger to consumers
Falsification or fabrication	Changing or inventing data to support a desired outcome	A company boasts of a fictitious enterprise to lure investors into supporting a new venture
Overstatement or understatement	Exaggerating the positive aspects of a situation of downplaying negative aspects to create the desired impression	A public-opinion survey describes 55 percent of the respondents as a “substantial majority” and 45 percent as “a small percentage”
Selective misquoting	Deleting words from quoted material to distort meaning	A supervisor changes a report’s conclusion that “this proposal will seem feasible only to workers unfamiliar with the situation” to “this proposal will seem feasible.. to workers”
Subjective Wording	Using terms deliberately chosen for their ambiguity	A company advertises “customary service charges”, knowing that “customary” is open to broad interpretation.
Conflict of interest	Exploiting behind-the-scenes connections to influence decision-making	A board member of a community agency encourages the agency to hire her company for paid services rather than soliciting bids
Withholding information	Refusing to share relevant data with coworkers	A computer-savvy employee provides misleading answers about new software to make recently hired coworker appear incompetent
Plagiarism	Taking credit for someone else’s ideas, findings	An employee assigned to prepare a report written by someone at another company, downloaded from internet

Case-Study: Conflict of Interest

ABC Manufacturing Inc. is a mid-sized company specializing in producing eco-friendly packaging solutions. With a strong commitment to sustainability, the company has garnered a loyal customer base and established itself as an industry leader. Salman Ahmed, the Procurement Manager at ABC Manufacturing, is responsible for selecting suppliers for raw materials and negotiating contracts. Recently, the company has been seeking new suppliers to source a particular biodegradable material that is crucial to their product line.

Salman's brother-in-law, Atif, owns GreenSource Ltd., a supplier offering competitive prices for the required material. While GreenSource Ltd. seems like a promising option for ABC Manufacturing, Salman is aware that any decision favoring Atif's company could be perceived as a conflict of interest. Despite this, Salman is tempted to recommend GreenSource Ltd. because of their lower prices and the potential personal benefits of supporting a family member's business.

Questions for Discussion

Question 1: What steps should Salman take to address the potential conflict of interest?

Question 2: What policies should ABC Manufacturing implement to manage potential conflicts of interest in the future?

Question 3: How can ABC Manufacturing ensure that supplier selection remains fair and unbiased?

Question 4: How should ABC Manufacturing handle the situation if Salman fails to disclose the conflict of interest?

References

- S. Pfeiffer, William George. ***Technical Writing: A Practical Approach*** (Pearson), 2012
- Lannon & Gurak, ***Technical Communication.***, 14th Edition, 2016